Week 30

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 8 · LESSON 2

Questions

BIG IDEA

You don't need every answer to talk about your faith; good questions are the most valuable tool you have. Asking "What do you mean by that?" and "How did you come to that conclusion?" helps you understand, buys time to think, and shows real care for the person.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Loving people in conversation can feel terrifying, especially for introverts. Having a plan of attack helps, including when you're asked something you can't answer.
2. We feel we need every answer to convince someone. Nothing could be further from the truth: everyone gets stumped, and no one knows every belief.
3. This week is about the art of asking questions: not yes-or-no, but probing "why" questions that show genuine interest in what the other person thinks.
4. First question: "What do you mean by that?" It lets the person clarify what they believe, and it buys you time to think more carefully.
5. Second question: "How did you come to that conclusion?" Ask it with genuine interest, never with an attitude, so they see you want to know what they think.
6. Good questions are a form of love. They build a relationship, so if someone does come to Christ, discipleship can begin, not just a conversion.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. When I'm stumped in a conversation, do I rush to an answer or slow down and ask a question?
2. Which of my students find conversation hardest, and how can I help them build a plan?
3. How can I model the two questions in how I listen to my own group?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What part of talking about your faith feels hardest or scariest to you?
2. Why do we feel we have to have every answer, and what would change if we didn't?
3. If someone says Jesus was just a good moral teacher, how could asking what they mean open up the conversation?
4. How can the same question sound curious or sound like an attack? What makes the difference?
5. Who in your life could you have a real, question-filled conversation with this week?

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The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Going out is terrifying

0:05 Last week we talked about the need for love when we're engaging in conversation. We want to get out there, and we want to be loving to other people. But if you or any of your students are like me, that very concept is terrifying. It's the fact that I have to go out — not the love part, that's not so terrifying, but the part where you go out and actually have a conversation. That part is terrifying. I need a plan of attack. I am very introverted and very reserved, and I'm sure some of your students are too. I'm not all that good at small talk, at just having a conversation. In fact, I actively try to avoid small talk. I like to get to the point.

When you can't answer

0:47 So when I'm entering a conversation about spiritual things, or when I want to advance a conversation and get to the gospel so that I can get to Jesus — because I want them to know who Jesus is — I need a plan of attack. But I'm sure that many of your students, and maybe you yourself, ask this, because I know I get there all the time: what happens when they ask you a question that you can't answer? Here is what happens in those moments. Somebody asks us a question.

1:16 We immediately want to have an answer, to come right back and say, "Yeah, I've got that answer, and I've got that answer," because we feel like if we have all of the answers, then we can somehow convince the other person that what we believe is absolutely right — we've got all the answers to all their questions. Well, nothing could be further from the truth. That's not at all the case. There are going to be times when we get stumped and we don't know what to say, or the person we're talking to has a belief system or a view on things that we're just not all that familiar with. You can't know everything about every single person.

The art of asking questions

1:47 But there's a really simple strategy that I want you to add in and to talk about with your students: when they're engaged in a conversation, you want to make sure that you are asking questions. That's what this week is all about — the idea and the art of asking questions. Questions are so, so important. If we ask good questions, then we're probably going to get good answers. Just like any good teacher knows, you don't ask yes-or-no questions. You ask in-depth, probing questions — "why" kinds of questions — to draw out of people the answers that you want, the answers that you need.

2:29 The same holds true in our conversations. This especially works if you have no idea what the other person is talking about, because you can probe a little bit deeper and get them to talk it through. At the same time, you're giving off the idea — because you are, and because you want to be — that you're extremely interested in what they have to say. That goes back to last

week, when we talked about love and building relationships and that sort of thing. So there are two specific questions that we can ask somebody if you get stumped.

What do you mean by that?

2:59 The first question is simple: what do you mean by that? This question is used when you're really not sure what the person thinks, when the person says something that you're just not all that clear on. "I believe that Jesus is just a good moral teacher." What do you mean by that? You can probably guess what they might mean, but maybe that's not it at all. "God just doesn't exist, because there's too much evil in the world." Well, what do you mean by that? You can "what do you mean by that" people to death. You can go over and over and over again: what do you mean by that, or some variation of it.

3:50 It's a very simple question, but it does two things. First, it digs deeper into the person and what they're actually thinking. Second, it buys you time to think about what you want to say. It allows them to clarify what they're saying, so they can't just make a one-off statement to you, and it buys you a little bit of time to think through their opinion more thoroughly and more thoughtfully.

How did you come to that?

4:14 The second question is: how did you come to that conclusion? Again, people make one-off statements all the time. How did they get there? So if they said something like, "God can't exist because there's too much evil in the world" — well, how do you come to that conclusion? There's a much larger explanation that I need for that. And you don't say it with an attitude; you say it as someone who is genuinely interested. How did you come to that conclusion? Really? I really want to know. I'm really interested in what you have to say.

4:53 What this does is help them see that you are actually interested in what they have to say, that you actually want to know what they think rather than just giving them what you think. There's a big difference between the two. And again, that's why last week and this week are connected together, because by doing this kind of thing you're showing them love, you're showing them relationship, you're showing that you care about them as a person and not just feeding them your opinion.

The most valuable tool

5:20 The most valuable tool that you or your students have is the ability to sit down face-to-face with somebody and have a conversation. There are a lot of tips and tricks to sharing your faith, but the number one thing to keep in your toolbox is the ability to ask great questions and to engage in deep, meaningful conversations with another person. It does so much more than just give the gospel. It builds relationship, so that when that person finally receives Christ, discipleship can actually begin, rather than just a conversion.